Essentials

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/52285621.

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General Audiences

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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Adora (She-Ra), faceless soldiers

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Alternate Universe - Ancient, or medieval if you'd like, Catra Leaves the Horde (She-Ra), Horde Adora (She-Ra), Angst, Period-Typical Slavery

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by itsaboringname

Summary

General Adora announces to her army that they will go on a difficult march, and leaves some things behind.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

It's a bright, clear morning. By the encampment hearth, the red banners flutter loudly in the wind. There's a chill in the air. Before the hearth, the soldiers stand ready in ranks, filling the neat rectangle. Their pale-eyed general watches them without blinking, as her porters carry up the rolls of her pavilion and rugs and deposit them in a pile. Around them, the camp is quiet and the civilians and slaves of the army are coming to a stop, watching her as well.

As if to prompt her, the wind shifts in a strong gust, making the flames hiss and the banners slap. She doesn't flinch and she doesn't smile, but she relaxes her grip on the item she holds behind her back. Her armor creaks quietly as her posture gets just a little bit easier.

When Adora looks into the eyes of her soldiers, she sees expectance, boredom, calm assurance, worry, fear, hope, admiration. In that moment she truly feels like they are her children, and she their proud parent, who will now for the first time truly depend on them as adults in their own right. She believes in them; they will not fail her now. With some unspoken agreement, the heavens, the camp, the soldiers, and the fire all become perfectly quiet and still and she knows the time has come.

"Hordesmen!" she calls them, and the army answers with a single, sharp, deafening "Hou!"

She doesn't smile then either, but there's a slight tightening of her lips that almost looks like she does. "For a year now, we've been trading blows with the princesses where they have chosen to meet us. For a year, I have asked you to bleed for me, in places where our enemy is strong. For a year, we have been frustrated by a traitor to our own cause! That ends now."

There's not a word from the ranks, only intense, agreeing stares. They look to her for guidence.

Under the curious eyes of soldiers and followers alike, she turns away and hefts one of the fine rolled-up rugs she has had brought up over her shoulder. He entire baggage lies piled there now, save for a few things still on their way. Without a word and with stately control she turns her back to the troops and throws the roll onto the pyre. It flares, and flares higher when she splashes oil over the thick thing from a brass pitcher. Only when satisfied that it's catching well does she turn back to her soldiers.

"Every soldier will carry everything they require themselves. In each squadron, one will carry the tent and the others will share their pack amongst themselves."

Some widen their eyes in disbelief as if to say, you can't be serious? Most are unbothered or thoughtful, some even nod approvingly. Adora throws another rug on the fire. The blue one from Thaymor that she took from the office of the magistrate there - she feels something to see it's strands blacken and curl. Then she imagines that that feeling itself was what was blackening and curling, and it helps. The fingers of her left hand are still closed around the smooth thing.

"We will discard everything other than our armaments," and she bashes her vambrace against her gleaming breastplate which is a sign for her soldiers to answer with the same. "And what we need to survive. Every idol and trinket that your duty does not need, you will leave behind. Every slave in the camp will be set free and every civilian except the medics and the quartermasters and their helpers will be sent away."

There's another little smattering of quiet reactions, but the general idea seems to be settling. She doesn't look at the campers, but doesn't imagine that anyone but the slaves is happy about it. "The mules will be loaded with water and the rations will be reduced to hardtack. As the mules drop, they will provide our meat."

Another bitter pill to swallow, that she punctuates with pouring oil over the rest of her belongings and pulling the burning rugs back

down onto it. With grim satisfaction, she watches the flames catch for a few moments before again turning to the soldiers. "We will march for forty days with no rest. We will have only what we bring with us."

With another gust of wind, the big pile of her ostentatious commander's baggage sends up a huge lick of flame. The eyes on her are wide and apprehensive, but open. She's got no doubt in her mind that they will follow her into the fiery pit itself if she asks them to, and wonders absently how many of them have guessed it.

"We will make Lord Hordak proud with our tenacity, because we will cross the Crimson Wastes." A ripple passes through the camp. Nobody crosses the Crimson Wastes, nobody goes there, nobody comes from there. But they don't say a word, they don't shuffle and fidget and they don't look away. My soldiers, she thinks. Her face tightens again to an almost-smile.

"We will walk across the anvil of the sun. There won't be anyone alive for the rest of this world that won't have heard about what the red banner of the horde did, but there's only two things I want you to think about when we're out there. The first thing, is I want you to remember the humiliation and the scorn when they ran us about in the valley of Elberon. When the traitor Catra," and she calls the name like a curse because it's the only way she could speak it without catching, "tricked us at Thaymor and turned us back with her trechery." She pauses for a moment to harden her stare just that bit more. "Savor your spite, becuase the other thing I want you to think about is the rich, green pastures of Brightmoon. We will be there just as the harvest is taken in. Think about that princess land, it's open and unguarded vineyards and orchards. We will walk through hell and when we come out the other side we will be demons coming to a feast of blood!"

She'd planned more or less what she was going to say. She had some more things she was going to say too, but the pertinent information had been conveyed. The eyes of the soldiers were grimly enthusiastic, so she shot her right fist into the air. "For the

horde," she saluted them and without hesitation they replied in kind. Three times did they repeat. Then, breaking into an earnest smile she didn't expect, she dismissed them with a wave. Like a tower of sand smashed by a kick, the great rectangle of quiet soldiers dissolved and collapsed into rapid, chaotic movement.

Her smile didn't last, they never do these days. There was too many things missing, too many reminders, too much baggage. She doesn't need any of it. It's just her, her soldiers, the desert and the enemy. She has a role to play and things that don't matter for that, she can throw away. For the first time since stepping out of her tent and ordering the slaves to take it down and pile it all next to the camp hearth she looks at the thing in her hand.

It's the same blue as her eye. Whenever she sees it in bright sunlight like this, it still manages to take her by surprise how spot on it is. About as big as a small chicken egg, perfect size to hold in her hand. Smooth but not even. She's had it for so many years now. Adora never knew how much it could mean to her, while *she* was still around. Now it's all she has left. No, she tells herself desperately and grips the stone tighter. This isn't something that I have left from her, this is something she left in me. It's like a poison that she left behind to weaken me with and the stone is the conduit through which the poison keeps seeping in. I just need to flick it away into the coals and it will be gone. It will be blackened and cracked and charred and gone.

She imagines throwing it away. She's imagined doing it many times before but now she has to. It's not for her, it's for her soldiers. She's expecting them, she's ordered her officers to make sure that they, throw away anything like it that they have. They're not just shedding their extra load, they're shedding who they have become while being made fools at the hands of the rebellion, in order to be able to turn into the remorseless creatures they will need to be when they descend on the heartland. With a sharp intake of breath, and a wince, she tosses it. Her eyes track it as it bounces on the side and disappears into a pile of white-hot embers.

The immediate reaction is to lunge after it, to pull out her sword and bat away the coals and recover her last link to the last thing in her life that really made sense. Instead she stands frozen, staring at the point it disappeared.

A trumpet call for the sentry change breaks her out of her revelry, and she goes to formally free and dismiss her own personal campers. There's a way before her and as long as Adora keeps her eyes on what's essential to her task and not at where her life disappeared to, nothing else needs to matter.

End Notes

I read a blog post about pre-railroad military logistics and it said that it was a trope for roman generals to throw away personal belongings as a gesture to inspire loyalty and fortitude when making difficult marches. then this fell out

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